

THE DARKNESS HIERARCHY

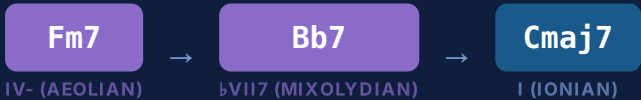
Seven modes arranged from brightest (Lydian) to darkest (Phrygian). Locrian is marked unusable. Each column shows the mode's characteristic note and most useful borrowed chords.

THE MODAL SPECTRUM — BRIGHTEST TO DARKEST

LYDIAN ETHEREAL #4 II (D) Bright lift, also V7/V #ivø7 Dark contrast from bright	IONIAN BASELINE Major I-vii° All 7 diatonic chords (home base) Nothing borrowed here	MIXO-LYDIAN BLUESY b7 bVII (Bb) Rock/blues feel v-7 Soft minor dominant	DORIAN DARK+HOPE nat.6 IV (D) Bright in minor key IV7 (D7) Even brighter color	AEOLIAN NATURAL MINOR b6 bVI (Ab) Epic, cinematic iv- (Fm) Dark subdominant	PHRYGIAN DARKEST b2 bII (Db) Exotic, dramatic bIIImaj7 Lush dark exotic	LOCRIAN x UNUSABLE b5 — Unstable tonic, no usable chords — Avoid for borrowing
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The borrowing rule: only borrow chords that CONTAIN the mode's characteristic note. Borrowing a chord that lacks the characteristic note adds no modal color — it's just a regular diatonic chord that doesn't signal the mode you're borrowing from.

THE BACKDOOR II-V — DARK MODE SUMMARY IN C MAJOR



The Backdoor ii-V uses borrowed chords from parallel minor (Fm7 from Aeolian, Bb7 from Mixolydian/Aeolian overlap) to arrive at the major tonic. The chromatic bass motion F → Bb → C creates a warm, inevitable feeling that's softer than the traditional ii-V-I but equally conclusive. This is the parallel-minor equivalent of the ii-V-I journey.